DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Body and Soul Together: Resurrection and Gan Eden

Derech Hashem, Maamar Halkarim

Sefer: Maamar Halkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar Halkarim, essay 4 (second half) and essay 5: Gan Eden and Gehinnom **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 16 June 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

On Monday the group began the fourth essay. The Rabbi repeated that gemul is better translated "consequences" than "reward and punishment". Because we have free will, we form our own identity, and Olam HaBa is simply the materialisation of the choices we made. Some consequences are felt in this world, most in the World to Come, all according to God's wisdom.

Why the body must share the reward

The Ramhal continues: since in this world body and soul act together in every misvah and every sin, the consequences must also come to both together.

Here the Rabbi stressed the definitions again. Olam HaBa is not Gan Eden and Gehinnom. It comes after Mashiah, after the Temple, after the resurrection and after Gan Eden and Gehinnom. The Ramhal, like the Ramban, holds that since our actions were done with the body, it would be unfair for the body to have no share in the result. So in Olam HaBa we will exist body and soul together.

The Rambam disagreed and held that Olam HaBa is purely spiritual, only souls. The Rabbi suggested the gap may be smaller than it looks. The Ramban writes clearly that the bodies of Olam HaBa will not be the bodies we have now. They will not crave food and drink, but will be an elevated body like Adam's before the sin. What the Rambam is really excluding is a body like ours, with good and bad mixed together, and on that everyone agrees.

Death and resurrection

Because of Adam's sin, all humanity must pass through death. There is a kind of contamination in the body from that sin which prevents it from fully enjoying God's light. Only when the body returns to the earth is it cleansed, and then it is rebuilt without that flaw. The soul returns to it, and together they enjoy eternity, each according to its level. That rebuilding is Tehiyat HaMetim, the resurrection of the dead.

The Rabbi noted, as in his earlier series on the Thirteen Principles, that the resurrection was difficult for the Rambam. His contemporaries even accused him of not believing in it, and he had to write a whole essay, Maamar Tehiyat HaMetim, to show that he did.

The problem, he explained, is where it fits in the Rambam's system. For the Ramhal it fits beautifully. We live body and soul; we die; the body lies in the grave while the soul waits in Gan Eden or Gehinnom; and when Olam HaBa arrives, body and soul are reunited, in a refined, "refurbished" body. But for the Rambam, Olam HaBa is souls alone. So after Mashiah the dead rise, live for a time, and then everyone returns to dust and lives on as souls. "What's the point?" Those who were waiting as souls could simply have kept waiting. "For the Rambam it makes no sense, and there's no explanation to this."

What the Gemara says

A participant asked how the Rambam and the Ramhal reached their views. The Rabbi answered that both start from the Gemara's statement that in Olam HaBa there is no eating, drinking or marital relations. For the Rambam that means no body. For the Ramhal it means no eating and drinking as we know them now, though there will be a body. Asked what the Zohar says, he said he did not know of a source there.

Essay 5: the waiting room

The final paragraph of essay 4 leads into essay 5. While the body is in the grave, the soul, if it merits, rests in the world of souls. This is a temporary place where it receives a taste of Olam HaBa according to its deeds, but nothing comparable to the real thing.

The Rabbi set out the working definitions:

- **Olam HaZeh**, this world, which will also include the days of Mashiah and the resurrection.
- **Olam HaNeshamot**, the world of souls, with two parts: Gan Eden and Gehinnom.
- **Olam HaBa**, the renewed world that follows.

Gan Eden is the place of rest until the resurrection. It has levels. In the lower Gan Eden souls still have a kind of physical garment and enjoy spiritual pleasure suited to them. In the upper Gan Eden they are complete and their enjoyment is far greater. At certain times, such as Shabbat, a soul may rise from one to the other. The Zohar speaks of seven levels altogether.

The Rabbi pointed out that the main book never once mentions Gan Eden or Gehinnom. "It's a waiting room." Your place there reflects your future place in Olam HaBa: a front seat there means the upper Gan Eden, a back seat means the lower Gan Eden or a period in Gehinnom first. A participant suggested that a soul in the lower Gan Eden still feels a pull towards the body. The Rabbi agreed that something holds it back, like a cloak, and that this may be released, but the identity formed in life remains. "You're going to be B. You're not going to be A star."

Gehinnom: purging, not punishment

The second place in the world of souls is for purification through suffering, according to what each soul needs. This, said the Rabbi, is the only real concept of punishment in Judaism. Afterwards the soul is purified and receives its good. Only those who cannot be purified even

then are cut off and cease to exist, and they are very few, because a single sincere misvah done for no honour, money or return must be rewarded.

So anyone going through Gehinnom has not been cut off. Gehinnom lasts at most twelve months, and that person will still be resurrected. Only the completely wicked, "a bruised apple inside out", are cut off.

What is the fire of Gehinnom? A participant described the soul's life being replayed like a hard drive, with the shame of everything one did. The Rabbi agreed that it is not a physical fire but shame, which can be very intense depending on who you are and what you did.

The next essay would be on hashgahah, Divine providence.

Summary

- Body and soul act together, so for the Ramhal they share the consequences together in an elevated body.
- Death cleanses the body of Adam's sin, and the resurrection rebuilds it for eternity.
- The Rambam's purely spiritual Olam HaBa makes the resurrection hard to place in his system.
- Gan Eden and Gehinnom are a temporary waiting room; Olam HaBa is the real goal.
- Gehinnom is purification lasting at most twelve months; only the completely wicked are cut off.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/Mfwnayb22ww · More shiurim: rabbikada.com